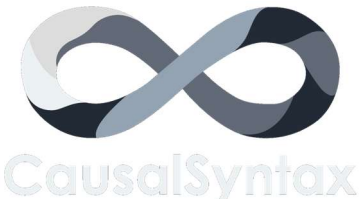
circles

The internet's reading room.

Product Requirements Document & Roadmap

Version 4.0 | March 2026 | Pre-Seed

Product	Circles
Stage	Pre-Seed / Ideation
Category	Hybrid Async/Sync Social Network
Tagline	The internet's reading room.
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1. Executive Summary & Vision

Vision Statement

Circles is the digital twin of the cafe and the library — an anti-vanity social network that seamlessly transforms shared interests into authentic, live conversations. It brings back the lost Third Place by replacing algorithmic outrage and performative metrics with deep content consumption and serendipitous, organic human connection.

Core Paradigm

Users do not come to Circles primarily to chat. They enter a Reading Room to consume high-value content precisely tailored to specific facets of their identity. Social interaction is entirely opt-in — an organic byproduct of occupying that intellectual space — replicating the feeling of making eye contact and striking up a conversation with a stranger reading the same book at a teashop.

The Opportunity in One Line

Every existing social platform optimises for attention. Circles optimises for resonance.

Founding Context

Circles is the pilot product of CausalSyntax — a product company founded by **Arun Mohanan** with the mission of building human-centric digital spaces that respect attention, protect identity, and reward depth of engagement over breadth of reach. CausalSyntax is the house under which Circles and future products will be built, headquartered at causalsyntax.com.

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2. Problem Statement

Pain Point	Current Alternative	Circles Solution
Performative social media fatigue	Twitter/X, LinkedIn	Zero vanity metrics; no public likes or follower counts
Context collapse across identities	Single-profile networks	Isolated Personas per interest domain
Cold-start for new communities	Discord, Slack	Interest-tagged Reading Room from Day 1
Serendipity is dead online	Algorithmic feeds	Ambient Collision Engine surfaces live co-presence
Shallow live interactions	Twitter Spaces, Clubhouse	Graduated: Note → Handshake → Table → Bloom
No digital Third Place	None	The Lobby replicates cafe-style organic social gravity

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3. Target Audience & Identity Architecture

Primary User Archetypes

Archetype	Description	Core Need
The Evening Regular	Professionals unwinding after work who crave casual, unstructured intellectual discussion without audience-building pressure	Low-friction ritual; serendipitous discovery
The Circle Seeker	Individuals actively forming functional cohorts — founders seeking co-founders, developers seeking collaborators, researchers seeking peers	Trust-based matchmaking beyond LinkedIn
The Multifaceted Self	Users with distinct, non-overlapping identities (e.g., a VC by day and a jazz musician by night)	No context collapse; true pseudonymity
The Knowledge Curator	Domain experts willing to host Stage events, share curated RSS stacks, and build reputation within a niche	Monetisable thought leadership without follower theatre

Identity Architecture: Dual-Identity System

- **Base Profile (Private):** Legal name, master email, date of birth — stored securely, never surfaced publicly.
- **Personas (Faceted):** Multiple isolated identities per user. Each Persona has its own alias, avatar, interest tags, Feed Wall, and collision history.
- **Privacy Matrix:** Users explicitly toggle which Base Profile attributes (e.g., Location: 'Kerala, India') are shared on each Persona to establish contextual trust without full disclosure.
- **No Context Collapse:** Each Persona is hermetically sealed. Activity, conversations, and connections in one Persona are invisible to others.

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4. Product Architecture & Core Mechanics

Circles is structured as six sequential interaction phases, each unlocking the next through explicit user intent.

Phase 1 — The Reading Room (Feed Wall)

The anchor experience. A curated, single-player library ensuring zero cold-start friction.

- **Content Mix:** RSS-pulled articles, global news APIs, study reports, native webinars, and curated book recommendations — all mapped to the active Persona's interest tags.
- **Zero Vanity:** No public likes, no comment sections, no follower counts.
- **Book Shelf:** Curated books are surfaced inline in the Feed Wall alongside articles. Users add titles to a personal Reading List. For physical books, an affiliate purchase link routes to retail partners. For paid eBooks, the user can purchase and read entirely within the app via an embedded reader. Free eBooks open directly in-app. Circles earns affiliate commission on physical book sales and a platform margin on in-app eBook purchases.
- **Contextual Sponsored Cards:** Domain-matched sponsored content (courses, certification programmes, workshops) appears as clearly-labelled cards in the Feed Wall — at most 1 per 10 items. Sponsored cards are never shown inside active Lobbies, Tables, or Live Circles. See Section 7 for the full Sponsored Connection mechanic.

Phase 2 — The Ambient Lobby (Passive Matchmaking)

- **Collision Engine:** A background service continuously detects overlapping online Personas sharing interest tags and generates transient Lobbies.
- **Ambient Cue:** The user's active Persona avatar on the Feed Wall begins to gently glow — a soft, non-intrusive signal of co-presence.
- **Lobby View:** Switching to the Persona Dashboard reveals active Lobby cards (e.g., '6 Personas exploring Solopreneurship') including each Persona's alias, disclosed location, and tags.

Phase 3 — The Open Note & Handshake (Icebreaking)

- **Open Note:** A short, contextual text message (max 150 characters) dropped into the Lobby, visible to all occupants.
- **Handshake:** Any Persona can reply directly to an Open Note. The original author accepts or ignores — no unsolicited audio, ever.

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Phase 4 — The Table (Audio Micro-Channels)

- **Spatial Isolation:** Upon a successful Handshake, the two Personas' avatars snap together visually into a 'Table' within the Lobby UI.
- **Audio-First:** An isolated WebRTC audio channel opens exclusively between them. Other Lobby occupants cannot hear the conversation.
- **Dynamic Expansion:** While at a Table, users can still read Lobby notes and Handshake a third Persona, seamlessly merging them into the existing audio channel.

Phase 5 — The Bloom & Roots (Persistence)

- **Bloom Request:** Any Table member requests a private space. Unanimous consent from all Table members extracts the group into a dedicated Live Circle.
- **Video Escalation:** Inside the Live Circle, any user can request cameras on. This requires unanimous consent; without it, the room remains strictly audio.
- **No-Trace Rule (Default):** All conversation data evaporates on exit. Groups may opt to 'Plant Roots' to save the Circle and enable future async meetups.

Phase 6 — The Stage (Broadcasting & Webinars)

- **Event Scheduling:** Verified Personas or organisations schedule Stage events (Free or Ticketed) with tags for discoverability.
- **Discovery:** Stage cards embed natively in relevant Personas' Feed Walls.
- **Mechanics:** Broadcaster (A/V enabled) + Audience (listen-only) model with a Stage Sandbox for Q&A notes.
- **Replays:** Hosts record and publish Stages; replays appear in attendee feeds.

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5. Detailed User Flows & Edge Cases

Flow 1 — Onboarding & Identity Generation

- **Step 1: Auth:** Magic Link (email) or OAuth (Google/Apple). No password required.
- **Step 2: Base Setup:** User submits private PII: Full Name, Date of Birth, Master Email. Stored encrypted; never displayed.
- **Step 3: Persona Creation:** User defines Alias, selects Core Interest Tags (min 2, max 10), sets Privacy Matrix toggles, and selects an avatar from a generated set.
- **Step 4: Entry:** App drops user directly into the Reading Room for Persona A. Feed is immediately populated — zero cold-start.

Edge Cases:

- User skips Persona creation → Blocked with a contextual prompt explaining why Personas are required; cannot proceed without at least one.
- Magic Link expires (>15 min) → One-tap resend with a 60-second cooldown and a clear error message.
- Underage user detected (DoB < 18) → Graceful rejection with explanation; account not created.

Flow 2 — The Lobby & Connection

- **Trigger:** Avatar glows softly while user reads. Tap → Persona Dashboard flips open.
- **Lobby Selection:** User taps a Sandbox Card (e.g., '4 active now — UX Design').
- **Open Note:** User types (max 150 chars): 'Anyone transitioning from Figma to code?'
- **Handshake:** User B replies. User A accepts. Avatars snap together. Microphones activate.

Edge Cases:

- Lobby dissolves mid-session (all others leave) → User is gracefully returned to the Feed Wall with a soft toast notification.
- User ignores Handshake for >5 min → Request auto-expires. No notification spam.
- User drops a note but then switches Persona → Note is retracted from Lobby automatically.
- Microphone permission denied → Prompt with OS-level settings deeplink; cannot enter audio without permission.

Flow 3 — Bloom, Video Escalation & Roots

- **Bloom Request:** Any Table member taps 'Bloom'. All members receive a consent prompt with a 30-second window.
- **Rejection Handling:** If any member declines, Bloom is cancelled and all parties remain at the Table. No hard feelings mechanic — decliner is anonymous.

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- **Video Escalation:** Inside Live Circle, 'Request Video' triggers a consent modal for all participants. Any single decline keeps the room audio-only.
- **Plant Roots:** On exit, a prompt offers 'Save this Circle?' — opt-in only. Saves Persona aliases (not Base Profiles) and a title.

Edge Cases:

- Network drop mid-Bloom → User is held in a reconnect state for 30 seconds before being gracefully removed. Other participants are notified with a subtle indicator.
- User closes app during active Table → Session is held for 60 seconds; on return, they rejoin seamlessly.
- All-hands consent timeout (30s) → Request expires, status quo maintained.

Flow 4 — Guest Drop-In via External Link

- **Step 1:** Host taps 'Invite' → generates a magic share URL with a 24-hour TTL.
- **Step 2:** Non-user clicks link. App/PWA opens. Prompted only for a Temporary Alias and one Interest Tag.
- **Step 3:** Dropped directly into active Live Circle audio — bypasses full onboarding.
- **Step 4:** On session end, prompted to create a full account. Guest session data is not retained.

Edge Cases:

- Link expired → Clear error screen with option to request a new link from the host.
- Circle ended before guest joins → Informative landing screen; option to join the host's Lobby instead.
- Guest attempts to Bloom or Plant Roots → Blocked with a prompt to create a full account.

Flow 5 — Hosting a Stage

- **Scheduling:** Host creates Stage: title, tags, date/time, free vs. ticketed (Stripe integration), max audience size.
- **Discovery:** Stage card appears on matched Personas' Feed Walls up to 7 days before the event.
- **RSVP & Join:** Users tap RSVP. At T-0, tap 'Join Stage' → enter as audience (listen-only).
- **Q&A:** Audience drops notes into the Stage Sandbox. Host promotes notes to 'live question' status.
- **Recording & Replay:** Host toggles recording. On end, transcript + audio is saved. Replay pushed to attendee feeds within 2 hours.

Edge Cases:

- Host disconnects mid-Stage → 60-second reconnect window shown to audience; if host doesn't return, Stage ends gracefully with an automatic replay post.
- Ticketed Stage — payment failure → User cannot join; shown payment retry flow.

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- Max audience hit → Overflow waitlist shown with live count.

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6. Technical Architecture

System Overview

Circles is a hybrid real-time/async platform. The architecture separates concerns cleanly into four service domains: Content, Identity, Presence, and Communication.

Core Service Domains

Domain	Key Services	Recommended Stack
Identity & Auth	Dual persona management, Privacy Matrix enforcement, Magic Link / OAuth	Supabase Auth + Row-Level Security; JWT with per-Persona claims
Content / Feed	RSS aggregation, News API integration, Feed ranking, Commerce injection	Python (Celery) workers; PostgreSQL + Redis cache; custom lightweight ranker (no ML in MVP)
Presence & Collision	Online status per Persona, Lobby formation, Ambient cue triggers	Redis pub/sub for presence; serverless collision worker (Node.js) on 30s poll cycle
Real-Time Comms	WebRTC audio/video (Table & Live Circle), Stage broadcasting, Open Notes relay	LiveKit (SFU) for WebRTC; Supabase Realtime for Notes; Mux for Stage recording/replay
Payments	Ticketed Stages, Consultation Circle bookings	Stripe Connect; webhooks into internal events service
Notifications	Handshake alerts, Bloom consent, Stage reminders	Push via Expo (mobile); Web Push API (PWA); no email for in-session events

Data Privacy & Compliance

- **Encryption at Rest:** All PII in Base Profiles encrypted with AES-256 at the database level.
- **Encryption in Transit:** TLS 1.3 for all API traffic; DTLS/SRTP for all WebRTC streams.
- **No-Trace Rule Implementation:** Live Circle audio/video is never persisted server-side by default. Signalling metadata (room ID, Persona IDs) is purged within 24h of session end unless Roots are planted.
- **GDPR / DPDP Compliance:** Right to erasure implemented at both Base Profile and individual Persona levels. Data export includes all Persona activity but never cross-Persona linkage.

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- **Persona Isolation:** Database-level row-level security ensures zero cross-Persona data leakage — not just application-layer logic.

MVP Technical Constraints & Decisions

- **No ML in MVP:** Feed ranking is chronological + tag-match weighted. True personalisation is a Phase 2 investment.
- **Audio-First Priority:** Video is gated behind explicit consent and is deprioritised in the MVP build to reduce LiveKit cost and complexity.
- **LiveKit vs. Daily.co:** LiveKit is open-source and self-hostable, reducing per-minute costs significantly for a pre-revenue product.
- **Mobile-First, PWA Second:** React Native (Expo) for iOS/Android. PWA for Guest Drop-In links only.
- **Scalability Gate:** Collision Engine is the most computationally intensive component. Cap Lobby size at 50 concurrent Personas in MVP; shard at scale.

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7. Monetisation & Business Model

Revenue Architecture

Circles' monetisation is built on a fundamental principle: revenue must reinforce, not erode, the core user experience. Every monetisation lever either adds direct value to the user or connects two willing parties — no intermediary data brokering, no attention harvesting.

Revenue Streams Overview

Stream	Model	MVP / Later	Notes
Circles Pro (Subscription)	₹499/mo or ₹3,999/yr	MVP (Month 6+)	Unlimited Personas, advanced Privacy Matrix, Roots history, Stage analytics, priority Collision Engine weighting, offline eBook downloads
Stage Tickets	5–15% platform fee per ticket	MVP	Host sets price; Stripe handles payouts; Circles takes a cut. Free Stages remain free forever.
Sponsored Connections	CPM on card impressions + 20% fee on booked sessions	Month 6+	Tag-matched sponsor cards in Feed Wall. User raises an Interest Flag and sets availability windows. Sponsor books a session via app — user's PII is never shared.
eBook Sales	15–30% platform margin on paid eBook purchases	Month 6+	Paid eBooks purchased and read in-app via embedded reader. Circles negotiates content licensing with publishers and aggregators (e.g., Storytel API, direct publisher deals).
Physical Book Affiliate	4–8% affiliate commission per sale	MVP (Month 4+)	Affiliate links to Amazon, Flipkart. Lightweight to implement; immediate revenue from Day 1 of book feature launch.
Circles for Teams (B2B)	Per-seat SaaS, ₹200/seat/mo	Phase 2	Private Lobbies + Stages for companies; HR-verified Base Profiles; integrates with Slack/Notion.
Data Insights (Aggregated)	B2B reports to research firms	Phase 3	Strictly aggregated, anonymised trend data. Zero individual-level data. Opt-in at org level only.

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Feature Deep-Dive: The Book Shelf

The Book Shelf is a natural extension of the Reading Room philosophy — Circles as a library, not a social feed. Books are surfaced as first-class content items alongside articles, tagged and ranked by Persona interest match.

Book Type	User Flow	Revenue Model
Free eBook	Tap card → opens in embedded in-app reader instantly. User can add to Reading List, highlight passages, and drop a note into a matched Lobby ('Just read ch. 4 of...')	Zero revenue. Drives engagement and Reading List habit formation.
Paid eBook	Tap card → preview shown (first chapter). User taps 'Buy & Read' → in-app purchase via App Store / Play Store billing or direct Stripe. Book unlocks in embedded reader immediately.	15–30% margin on sale price (after store cut). Circles negotiates content licensing with publishers/aggregators.
Physical Book	Tap card → summary + reviews shown. User taps 'Buy Physical' → deep-links to Amazon/Flipkart with affiliate tag. Circles earns affiliate commission (4–8%) on completed purchase.	Affiliate commission. No inventory, no fulfilment. Pure margin.
Reading List	User saves any book (free, paid, physical) to a persistent Reading List on their Persona. Circles Pro users get unlimited list items; free users capped at 20.	Drives Pro conversion for avid readers.

Content Sourcing Strategy:

- **Phase 1 (MVP):** Open Library API + Project Gutenberg for free books. Manual curation of 200 seed titles per major interest domain. Affiliate links to Amazon/Flipkart for physical and paid editions.
- **Phase 2:** Direct publisher API integrations (e.g., Notion Press, Juggernaut) for Indian independent publishers. Explore Storytel or similar aggregator API for paid eBook catalogue.
- **Phase 3:** Negotiate revenue-share deals with major publishers (Penguin Random House India, HarperCollins India) for exclusive or early-access titles tied to Persona interest tags.

Feature Deep-Dive: Sponsored Connections

Sponsored Connections replace traditional interruptive advertising with a consent-gated, privacy-first mechanic. A sponsor (a course provider, certification body, professional programme) gets in front of a hyper-relevant audience. The user retains full control — no cold calls, no spam, no data leakage.

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The Sponsored Connection Flow

- **Step 1 — Card Impression:** A sponsored card appears in the Feed Wall, clearly labelled 'Sponsored' with the sponsor's Persona tag. Card contains: offering title, 2-line description, and a single CTA — 'I'm Interested'.
- **Step 2 — Interest Flag:** User taps 'I'm Interested'. A bottom sheet appears prompting them to select their available windows (e.g., 'Weekday evenings', 'Weekend mornings'). User submits. Their Persona ID and availability preferences are passed to the sponsor — zero PII.
- **Step 3 — Sponsor Schedules:** Sponsor sees a dashboard of anonymised Persona IDs who flagged interest, with their availability windows. Sponsor proposes a session time within the user's stated window.
- **Step 4 — User Confirms:** User receives an in-app notification: 'A sponsor has proposed a session on [date] at [time]. Accept or Decline?' User can review the sponsor's Persona card before accepting.
- **Step 5 — The Session:** On acceptance, a dedicated Consultation Circle (private Live Circle) opens at the scheduled time, connecting the user and the sponsor's representative. Audio-first; video requires user consent. User's contact info is never shared at any point.
- **Step 6 — Post-Session:** User can rate the sponsor (1–5 stars, internal only). Sponsors with < 3.5 average rating are suspended from the platform. User can permanently block the sponsor's future cards.

Sponsor Safeguards & Quality Controls

- **Tag Matching Threshold:** A sponsored card only appears on a Persona's Feed Wall if the sponsor's declared interest tags overlap ≥ 3 tags with the Persona. No untargeted broadcast.
- **Frequency Cap:** Maximum 1 sponsored card per 10 Feed Wall items per Persona per day. Hard-coded; not a configurable limit for sponsors.
- **No Lobby / Table / Circle Ads:** Sponsored content is strictly confined to the Feed Wall. The ambient social space is permanently ad-free.
- **Sponsor Verification:** All sponsors must complete organisation verification (GST/CIN number for Indian entities, equivalent for international) before accessing the platform.
- **User Opt-Out:** Any user can toggle 'No Sponsored Cards' per Persona at any time. Circles Pro users have this enabled by default.

Unit Economics (Pre-Seed Targets)

- **Target CAC (organic-first):** < ₹500 per activated user (defined as 2+ completed Handshakes).
- **Target LTV (Circles Pro):** ₹3,999/yr × average 2.5 year retention = ~₹10,000 LTV.

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- **LTV:CAC Ratio Target:** > 20:1 by Month 18 (achievable given near-zero paid acquisition in early cohorts).
- **Gross Margin Target:** > 70% on subscription revenue. eBook sales, Stage fees, and Sponsored Connections carry ~15–20% blended take rate. Physical book affiliate is near-100% margin.

Anti-Patterns Explicitly Avoided

- No advertising that interrupts active Lobbies, Tables, or Live Circles — ever.
- No selling or sharing individual-level user data under any commercial model.
- No cold-contact from sponsors: sessions only happen after explicit user Interest Flag and confirmed scheduling.
- No engagement-maximisation algorithms — feed ranking is relevance-weighted, not outrage-weighted.
- No dark patterns on subscription cancellation (one-tap cancel, no guilt loops).
- No DRM restrictions that prevent a purchased eBook from being read offline (Circles Pro feature).

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8. Success Metrics & KPIs

North Star Metric

Weekly Resonant Connections (WRC) — the number of unique pairs of users who complete a Handshake and spend ≥ 5 minutes at a Table in a given week.

WRC captures both platform health (people are connecting) and product quality (connections are substantive). It is deliberately not a vanity metric like DAU or sessions.

Metrics Framework by Layer

Layer	Metric	MVP Target	Definition
Acquisition	Organic Signups / Week	200 by Month 3	New Base Profiles created without paid ads
Activation	Persona Completion Rate	> 80%	Users who complete ≥ 1 full Persona setup
Engagement – Feed	Avg. Feed Read Time	> 8 min/session	Time in immersive article view per session
Engagement – Social	Lobby Entry Rate	> 40% of DAU	Daily active users who enter ≥ 1 Lobby
Engagement – Social	Handshake Conversion	> 25%	% of Open Notes that result in a completed Handshake
Retention – Core	D7 Retention	> 35%	Users returning within 7 days of first session
Retention – Core	D30 Retention	> 20%	Users returning within 30 days
Retention – Quality	Table Duration	Avg. > 12 min	Duration of completed Table conversations
Revenue	Pro Conversion Rate	> 4% of MAU	Free users converting to Circles Pro
Revenue	Stage GMV / Month	₹50K by Month 9	Gross ticket revenue through the platform
Revenue	Book Affiliate CTR	> 5% of book card views	Feed Wall book cards that result in a tap-through to purchase
Revenue	eBook Purchase Rate	> 1.5% of paid eBook impressions	Paid eBook cards that convert to an in-app purchase

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Revenue	Sponsored Connection Rate	> 8% of card impressions → Interest Flag	Sponsored cards that result in a user raising an Interest Flag
Revenue	Session Confirmation Rate	> 60% of Interest Flags → confirmed session	Interest Flags that result in a confirmed and attended session
Health	Collision Engine Efficacy	> 60%	% of Lobby entries that result in ≥ 1 Open Note
Health	Ghost Rate	< 10%	Users who enter a Lobby but never drop a note over 3+ visits

Guardrail Metrics (Never Sacrifice These)

- **Lobby Harassment Rate:** < 0.1% of Handshakes result in a block or report. Monitor weekly.
- **Audio Latency (P95):** < 300ms end-to-end for Table connections. Non-negotiable for conversation quality.
- **Persona Isolation Violations:** Zero. Any cross-Persona data leak is a Sev-1 incident.
- **False-Identity Rate:** < 2% of verified Personas contain demonstrably false Base Profile data (spot-check sample).

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9. Product Roadmap

The roadmap is structured in three 6-month phases aligned to fundraising milestones.

Phase	Timeline	Deliverables	Success Gate
Phase 0 Foundation	M0–M2	· Base Profile + Persona system · Reading Room (Feed Wall) with RSS + 2 News APIs · Magic Link + OAuth auth · Privacy Matrix · Basic Collision Engine (tag-match, no ML) · Book Shelf v1: free eBooks + physical affiliate links (Open Library API)	100 invited beta users; D7 retention > 30%; zero Persona isolation bugs; first affiliate book click tracked
Phase 1 Core Social	M3–M6	· Lobby UI + Open Notes · Handshake mechanic · Table (WebRTC audio via LiveKit) · Bloom + Live Circle · No-Trace Rule + Plant Roots · Guest Drop-In magic links · Reading List (save books to Persona) · Sponsored Connection cards + Interest Flag flow	WRC > 50/week; Handshake conversion > 20%; avg Table duration > 10 min; first Sponsored Connection session completed
Phase 2 Monetisation	M7–M12	· The Stage (free + ticketed) · Circles Pro subscription (incl. unlimited Reading List + no sponsored cards) · Paid eBook in-app purchases + embedded reader · Video escalation in Live Circles · iOS + Android public launch · Stage replay (Mux) · Sponsor dashboard + session rating system	₹10L MRR; Pro conversion > 4%; Stage GMV > ₹50K/month; eBook purchase rate > 1.5%
Phase 3 Expansion	M13–M18	· Circles for Teams (B2B) · ML-powered feed ranking (articles + books) · Publisher API integrations for paid eBook catalogue · Public Persona profiles (opt-in) · API for third-party integrations · Web app (full, not just PWA) · Book-based Lobby triggers ('X people reading this book')	Series A raise; 50K MAU; WRC > 500/week; LTV:CAC > 15:1

MVP Scope — Phase 0 & 1 Detailed Sprint Plan

Sprint	Focus	Key User Stories	Definition of Done
S1	Auth & Identity	As a user I can sign up via Magic Link and create my first Persona with at least 2 interest tags	Persona stored; Privacy Matrix functional; no PII in Persona schema

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S2	Feed Wall	As a user I can see a feed of articles matched to my Persona tags with no social metrics visible	Feed loads < 2s; RSS + 1 News API live; tag filter works
S3	Book Shelf v1	As a user I can see book recommendations in my Feed Wall, add them to my Reading List, and tap through to buy a physical book	Open Library API integrated; affiliate link tracked; Reading List persists across sessions
S4	Collision Engine v1	As a user I see my avatar glow when >= 2 other matching Personas are online	Presence service live; glow triggers correctly; < 5% false positives
S5	Lobby & Open Notes	As a user I can enter a Lobby, see Persona cards, and drop an Open Note	Notes appear in < 500ms; Lobby dissolves correctly when empty
S6	Handshake & Table	As a user I can accept a Handshake and open an audio channel with another user	WebRTC via LiveKit; audio < 300ms P95; graceful disconnect handling
S7	Bloom & Live Circle	As a group I can Bloom from a Table into a private Live Circle with unanimous consent	Consent flow correct; audio persists across transition; no data leaks
S8	Sponsored Connections v1	As a user I can tap 'I'm Interested' on a sponsored card, set my availability, and receive a session invitation without sharing my contact details	Interest Flag stored; availability window captured; sponsor notification sent; PII never exposed
S9	Guest Drop-In	As a non-user I can join a Live Circle via a magic link in < 60 seconds	Guest Persona created; drops into audio; full onboarding prompted on exit
S10	Polish & Beta	The app is stable, accessible, and ready for 100 invited users	No Sev-1 bugs; D7 retention measured; analytics pipeline live; affiliate and sponsored connection tracking verified

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10. Risks & Mitigations

Risk	Severity	Description	Mitigation
Cold Lobby Problem	High	If not enough users are online simultaneously, Lobbies never form and the core social mechanic fails	Seed with 'Evergreen Personas' — curated bot-like Personas that hold Lobbies open for human users until critical mass. Disclosed as AI.
WebRTC Latency / Quality	High	Poor audio quality destroys the cafe metaphor immediately	LiveKit SFU over peer-to-peer; aggressive P95 monitoring; auto-degrade to audio-only if video lags
Persona Impersonation	Medium	Users create Personas mimicking real individuals or brands	Report + review queue; verified badge for public figures; proactive trademark keyword blocking
Harassment in Lobbies	Medium	Open Notes could be used for unsolicited harassment	Mute/block at Persona level; note rate limiting (max 5 notes/Lobby/hour); AI moderation flag on Lobby notes
Monetisation vs. Trust	Medium	Contextual commerce and sponsorships could erode the anti-vanity brand	Hard caps on sponsored content (max 1 per 10 Feed items); user 'forever mute' per sponsor; no Lobby/Table ads ever
Regulatory (DPDP / GDPR)	Medium	India's Digital Personal Data Protection Act 2023 has strict consent and data localisation requirements	Data residency in India (AWS Mumbai); explicit consent per data processing purpose; appoint DPO before public launch
Founder-Market Fit Gap	Low	Team may not deeply represent the target user archetypes	Run 50-user qualitative research sprint before S1; embed 5 target users as paid beta advisors
eBook Licensing Complexity	Medium	Negotiating publisher licenses for paid eBooks is slow, expensive, and may stall Phase 2 revenue	De-risk by launching with free books (Open Library) + physical affiliate only in MVP. Paid eBooks enter only after first publisher deal is signed.
Sponsored Connection Abuse	Medium	Sponsors could game the Interest Flag system by using multiple accounts or misleading card descriptions to harvest availability data	Sponsor verification required (GST/CIN); session rating system (< 3.5 average = suspension); user can permanently block sponsor; Circles reviews flagged sponsors within 48h.

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11. Appendix

A. Glossary

- **Base Profile:** The private, legally-accurate identity layer. Never public.
- **Persona:** A user's faceted public identity within a specific interest domain.
- **Privacy Matrix:** The per-Persona toggle system controlling which Base Profile attributes are disclosed.
- **Feed Wall:** The Reading Room's main content surface — the library.
- **Collision Engine:** The background service detecting co-present Personas with matching tags.
- **Ambient Cue:** The avatar glow indicating an active Lobby is available.
- **Open Note:** A 150-character public message dropped into a Lobby.
- **Handshake:** A mutual, explicit consent mechanism to open an audio channel.
- **Table:** An isolated audio micro-channel between 2–N users within a Lobby.
- **Bloom:** The unanimous-consent mechanism to extract a group into a private Live Circle.
- **Live Circle:** A private, ephemeral audio (optionally video) room.
- **Plant Roots:** The opt-in mechanism to persist a Circle for future async meetups.
- **The Stage:** A structured broadcast event (free or ticketed) with a broadcaster/audience model.
- **WRC:** Weekly Resonant Connections — the North Star Metric.
- **Book Shelf:** The curated book recommendation layer of the Feed Wall; supports free eBooks, paid in-app eBooks, and physical affiliate purchases.
- **Reading List:** A per-Persona saved list of books (capped at 20 for free users; unlimited for Circles Pro).
- **Sponsored Connection:** A consent-gated, privacy-preserving advertising mechanic: a sponsor surfaces a card in the Feed Wall; the user raises an Interest Flag; a session is scheduled and held inside the app with zero PII transfer.
- **Interest Flag:** The user's explicit opt-in signal of interest in a sponsor's offering, accompanied by their stated availability windows. No PII is included.
- **Consultation Circle:** A private, scheduled Live Circle between a user and a sponsor's representative, opened only after mutual confirmation. Replaces cold-contact entirely.

B. Competitor Positioning

Product	Model	Core Mechanic	Circles Differentiation

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Clubhouse	Social Audio	Drop-in audio rooms	No serendipity mechanic; fame-based; Circles has ambient presence + Handshake consent
Twitter/X Spaces	Social Audio	Live audio tied to followers	Follower-dependent discovery; vanity metrics; Circles has zero follower counts
Discord	Community Chat	Persistent text/voice servers	Cold invite required; high friction; Circles has organic Lobby formation
Geneva	Group Chat	Interest-based group chats	No live co-presence; async only; Circles bridges reading + live
LinkedIn	Professional Network	Follower graph + feed	Resume theatre; vanity metrics; Circles replaces status with substance

C. Open Questions for Founding Team

- **Evergreen Personas:** How do we disclose the AI-seeded Personas ethically without undermining the organic feel?
- **Moderation at Scale:** At what MAU threshold do we hire a full-time Trust & Safety team vs. rely on AI moderation?
- **India-First vs. Global:** Should the MVP launch be India-exclusive (easier regulatory compliance, lower CAC) or globally accessible?
- **Persona Verified Badges:** What is the verification mechanism — government ID, LinkedIn OAuth, manual review?
- **Bloom Rooms Cap:** What is the maximum size of a Live Circle before it degrades to a Stage-like model?

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